

SCRIPTURES OF THE WORLD'S RELIGIONS



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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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Thumbnail: Stone carved Faravahar in Persepolis. (CC BY-SA 3.0; [Sahand Ace](#) via [Wikipedia](#))

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1.1: Ahura Mazda and Angra Mainyu

Ahura Mazda and Angra Mainyu (Bundahishn Ch. 1, verses 1-10)

This text discusses the high God of Zoroastrianism, Ahura Mazda, as well as the “Mazdayasnians,” which is another name for Zoroastrians, as this word translates to the “mazda worshippers”. This passage introduces the goodness, eternal nature, and omniscience of Ahura Mazda. But it also introduces the “evil spirit” of Zoroastrianism, who is known as “Angra Mainyu.”

The text discusses the differences between Ahura Mazda, whose main characteristic is light and everything that symbolically goes along with light – revelation, purity, etc. Angra Mainyu, on the other hand, is associated with darkness and everything that goes along with that quality – evil, temporality, emptiness, etc.

The passage wants to make very clear that Ahura Mazda and Angra Mainyu are completely separate from each other, although Ahura Mazda is more powerful and actually created Angra Mainyu.

Starting in Verse 8 the passage begins to tell part of the origin story of Zoroastrianism.

In Zoroastrian cosmology, it is believed that Angra Mainyu was created by Ahura Mazda, then remained at bay, in a “spiritual state” as the text describes, for three thousand years. Afterwards, he escaped from this state, which we could call hell as that is a term we may be more familiar with. Angra Mainyu and his creations, other evil spirits, are free to release evil and temptation on the world for a period of several thousand years, the time in which we are now living.

Ultimately, however, Zoroastrians believe that Ahura Mazda and his goodness will win out over Angra Mainyu. It is the responsibility of every human being to choose good over evil in this world, which helps to bring closer the ultimate conquering of evil in the world, and the ushering in of a perfect future state free from any evil and temptation.

Zoroastrianism believes that our world is a battleground between good and evil – it is our responsibility to work for the good in order to help goodness ultimately win and usher in the “future state,” which will be an eternal paradise once Angra Mainyu and his evil demons are defeated. Note the similarities between Angra Mainyu and the Christian and Muslim conceptions of the devil/shaytan – many scholars believe that Angra Mainyu influenced early Christian and Muslim conceptions of Satan.

It is important to note, however, that some Zoroastrians today see Angra Mainyu as a literal devil-like figure, while some Zoroastrians understand it to be a symbol of evil and temptation, not a real being.

Access the reading here:

I. https://holybooks-lichtenbergpress.netdna-ssl.com/wp-content/uploads/05.SacredBooksEast.VarOrSch.v5.Muller.Zor_West_PahlaviTxts.p1.Oxf_1880..pdf

i. Our passage is located on pages 3-6

The Bundahishn Chapter One

In the name of the creator Ahura Mazda

The Zand-akas (Zand-knowing or tradition informed), which is first about Ahura Mazda’s original creation and the antagonism of the evil spirit, and afterwards about the nature of the creatures from the original creation till the end, which is the future existence.

As revealed by the religion of the Mazdayasnians (Zoroastrians), so it is declared that Ahura Mazda is supreme in omniscience and goodness, and unrivalled in splendour; the region of light is the place of Ahura Mazda, which they call ‘endless light,’ and the omniscience and goodness of the unrivalled Ahura Mazda they call revelation.

Revelation is the explanation of both spirits together; one is he who is independent of unlimited time, because Ahura Mazda were and are and ever will be’ while Angra Mainyu in darkness, with backward understanding and desire for destruction, was in the abyss, and it is he who will not be; and the place of that destruction, and also of that darkness, is what they call the ‘endlessly dark’.

And between them was empty space, that is, what they call ‘air,’ in which is now their meeting.

Both are limited and unlimited spirits, for the supreme is that which they call endless light, and the abyss that which is endlessly dark, so that between them is a void, and one is not connected with the other; and, again, both spirits are limited as to their own selves.

And, secondly, on account of the omniscience of Ahura Mazda, both things are in the creation of Ahura Mazda, the finite and the infinite; for this they know is that which is in the covenant of both spirits.

And, again, the complete sovereignty of the creatures of Ahura Mazda is in the future existence, and that also is unlimited for ever and everlasting; and the creatures of Angra Mainyu will perish at the time when the future existence occurs, and that also is eternity.

Ahura Mazda, through omniscience, knew that Angra Mainyu exists, and whatever he schemes he infuses with malice and greediness till the end; and because He accomplishes the end by many means, He also produced spiritually the creatures which were necessary for those means, and they remained three thousand years in a spiritual state, so that they were unthinking and unmoving, with intangible bodies.

The evil spirit, on account of backward knowledge, was not aware of the existence of Ahura Mazda; and, afterwards, he arose from the abyss, and came in unto the light which he saw. Desirous of destroying, and because of his malicious nature, he rushed in to destroy that light of Ahura Mazda and he saw its bravery and glory were greater than his own; so he fled back to the gloomy darkness, and formed many demons and fiends; and the creatures of the destroyer arose for violence.

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1.2: The Coming of Saoshyant

Reading Two: The Coming of Saoshyant (Denkard Book 7, Ch. 10 Verses 15-19, Book 7, Ch. 11, Verses 4-5)

This passage discusses the events that will occur at the end of the current age, when the conquering of Angra Mainyu will begin to take place. Zoroastrians believe that an individual, called the “Saoshyant,” will usher in this era and lead the battle against Angra Mainyu. The Saoshyant is a savior-figure who will be born of a virgin, which the text calls “Gobakabu”. The text talks about her lineage and how she is a descendant of certain individuals. This is important for Zoroastrians because they believe that the Saoshyant will be a descendant of Zarathustra, the original prophet of Zoroastrianism. This text tells the story of how she will bathe in a lake and become impregnated with the seed of Zarathustra, which has been kept intact for thousands of years by angels. Then she will give birth to the Saoshyant.

The text continues to talk about the greatness of the Saoshyant, his goodness, his strength, and his abilities.

Then the text continues with discussing what will happen when the Saoshyant grows up, how he will destroy all the evil in the world and lead the true Mazda Worshippers to defeat Angra Mainyu and usher in the future existence. When he is 30 years old there will be a cosmic sign in the sky announcing his identity and then when he is 57 years old he will vanquish all evil from the world. Humanity will be released from evil and temptation, which is shown in the changing diet of humanity – the passage states that humans will become vegetarian, then drink only water, and then eat only “spiritual food.” Zoroastrians are not vegetarians, but these diet changes symbolize the bettering of humanity – they will no longer need the things of this world as they grow closer to God.

Scholars have often pointed to the similarities between the idea of Saoshyant and that of the “Mashiach” or Messiah in Judaism, which strongly influenced the beliefs surrounding Jesus in Christianity. Furthermore, the idea of the final battle between Saoshyant and Angra Mainyu has been compared to the final battle between the Messiah Jesus and the Anti-Christ from both Christianity and Islam.

The Saoshyant

And when thirty winters of the tenth century are unelapsed, that maiden, who is Gobakabu (translates to ‘having a testifying father’), walks up to the water; she that is the mother of that testifying Saoshyant who is the guide to conveying away the opposition of the destroyer, and her former lineage is from Vohurokoi Frahanyan in the family of Isadvastar, the son of Zaratusht that is brought forth by Arang.

That maiden whose title is all-overpowerer is thus all-overpowering, because through giving birth she brings forth him who overpowers all, both the affliction owing to demons, and also that owing to mankind.

Then she sits in that water, when she is fifteen years old, and it introduces into the girl him ‘whose name is the Triumphant Benefiter, and his title is the Bodymaker; such a benefiter as benefits the whole embodied existence, and such a bodymaker, alike possessing body and possessing life, as petitions about the disturbance of the embodied existences and mankind.

Not before that has she associated with men; nor yet afterwards, when she becomes pregnant, has she done so before the time when she gives birth. When that man becomes thirty years old, the sun stands still in the zenith of the sky for the duration of thirty days and nights, and it arrives again at that place where it was appointed by allotment.

[Then when Saoshyant is] fifty-seven years old there occur the annihilation of the fiendishness of the two-legged race and others, and the subjugation of disease and decrepitude, of death and persecution, and of the original evil of tyranny, apostasy, and depravity; there arise a perpetual verdant growth of vegetation and the primitive gift of joyfulness; and there are seventeen years of vegetable-eating, thirty years of water-drinking, and ten years of spiritual food.

And all the splendour, glory, and power, which have arisen in all those possessing splendour, glory, and power, are in him on whom they arrive together and for those who are his, when many inferior human beings are aroused splendid and powerful; and through their power and glory all the troops of the fiend are smitten. And all mankind remain of one accord in the religion of Ahura Mazda, owing to the will of the creator, the command of that apostle, and the resources of his companions.

Access the reading here:

https://holybooks-lichtenbergpress.netdna-ssl.com/wp-content/uploads/47.SacredBooksEast.VarOrSch.V47.Muller.Zor_.West_.p5.MarvelsZoroast.Oxf_.1897..pdf

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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Thumbnail: The Vedas are a large body of texts from ancient India. Composed in Vedic Sanskrit, the texts constitute the oldest layer of Sanskrit literature and the oldest scriptures of Hinduism. (CC BY-SA 4.0 International; [Preethi1830790](#) via [Wikipedia](#))

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2.1: Vedic Creation Hymn

Reading One: Vedic Creation Hymn (Rig Veda Book 10, Hymn 129)

This short passage is actually one of several creation hymns in the Vedas. There are several different stories and explanations of creation in the Hindu tradition, which underlies the main theme of this creation story – that no one knows exactly what happened at the creation of the world.

This hymn discusses skepticism at knowing exactly what existed at the beginning of existence, as it states that there was neither “existence nor non-existence” – most likely because those are human concepts and therefore meaningless beyond our realm.

The text refers to “that one” which is a reference to Brahman, the ultimate reality or Spirit of Hinduism. The term “God” is usually not used in reference to Brahman – words like “one”, “spirit”, or “unity” are often used instead.

The text also describes the beginning of existence as coming from “desire”, and “poets” who sought “wisdom” and therefore created a “bond”. This connects to one of the essential teachings of Hinduism, which is that the goal of all our lifetimes is to overcome desire for this world. Desire is what keeps us trapped in the cycle of reincarnation. When we give up the “desire” that creates a “bond” to this world, which in Hinduism is a form of ‘original sin’, then we can be released back to Brahman and eternal, perfect existence.

The last section of the hymn focuses on the unknowability of the specifics of the creation of the universe. The hymn mentions that not even the gods know, because they came “afterwards” – in Hinduism the gods are part of this creation, and also have to find their way back to Brahman. The hymn ends with the mysterious claim that maybe not even God himself, the “one who looks down on it” knows exactly how this universe came to be.

This hymn gives us an important insight into Hinduism, which does not emphasize believing in certain doctrines in order to return to God after death. It instead emphasizes that there are multiple paths, multiple understandings of the truth.

Vedic Creation Story

Then was not non-existent nor existent: there was no realm of air, no sky beyond it.
What covered in, and where? and what gave shelter? Was water there, unfathomed depth of water?
Death was not then, nor was there aught immortal: no sign was there, the day's and night's divider.
That One Thing, breathless, breathed by its own nature: apart from it was nothing whatsoever.
Darkness there was: at first concealed in darkness this All was indiscriminate chaos.
All that existed then was void and form less: by the great power of Warmth was born that Unit.
Thereafter rose Desire in the beginning, Desire, the primal seed and germ of Spirit.
Sages who searched with their heart's thought discovered the existent's kinship in the non-existent.
Transversely was their severing line extended: what was above it then, and what below it?
There were begetters, there were mighty forces, free action here and energy up yonder
Who verily knows and who can here declare it, whence it was born and whence comes this creation?
The Gods are later than this world's production. Who knows then whence it first came into being?
He, the first origin of this creation, whether he formed it all or did not form it,
Whose eye controls this world in highest heaven, he verily knows it, or perhaps he knows not.

Access the reading here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/rigveda/rv10129.htm>

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2.2: The Isha Upanishad

Reading Two: The Isha Upanishad

This Upanishad focuses on the “Self,” which is called the “atman” in Sanskrit. The atman is our eternal soul, the one part of us that does not die. For Hindus, this “Self” is also divine – so you will see in the passage that the “self” is often connected with the “Lord”. Our atman/self is our divine spark within us that connects us to Brahman.

This passage emphasizes the idea in Hinduism that one’s spiritual journey is the journey to understand our “self”, our soul. Hindus claim that coming to know the self will also lead one to better understand God, because our soul is divine.

So this passage focuses on how important our soul is, and so it should be the focus of our lives. Then the passage goes on to create a dichotomy between “real knowledge” and “not knowledge,” and that one will lead to eternal life and one will not. This section can be interpreted many ways (as all scripture can!) but the “not knowledge” is connected in the passage with “good works” while the “real knowledge” seems to focus on looking within and to the gods. So while the passage definitely doesn’t denigrate “good works,” it seems to insist that “good works” alone will not bring a person to true enlightenment. Good works have to be coupled with strong spiritual work focused on the Self.

One of the most important phrases in this Upanishad is the teaching that we should “see all beings in our self and our Self in all beings” – and that those who can do that will no longer have fear or taste death. Hinduism teaches not only is our soul the most important part of our being, and since our soul is divine, all beings have the same divine soul within them, making us all, ultimately, the same and unified.

Isha Upanishad

ALL this, whatsoever moves on earth, is to be hidden in the Lord (the Self). When thou hast surrendered all this, then thou mayest enjoy. Do not covet the wealth of any man!

Though a man may wish to live a hundred years, performing works, it will be thus with him; but not in any other way: work will thus not cling to a man.

There are the worlds of the Asuras (gods) covered with blind darkness. Those who have destroyed their self (who perform works, without having arrived at a knowledge of the true Self), go after death to those worlds.

That one (the Self), though never stirring, is swifter than thought. The Devas (senses) never reached it, it walked before them. Though standing still, it overtakes the others who are running. Mâtarisvan (the wind, the moving spirit) bestows powers on it.

It stirs and it stirs not; it is far, and likewise near. It is inside of all this, and it is outside of all this.

And he who sees all beings in the Self, and the Self in all beings, he never turns away from it.

When to a man who understands, the Self has become all things, what sorrow, what trouble can there be to him who once beheld that unity?

He (the Self) encircled all, bright, incorporeal, scatheless, without muscles, pure, untouched by evil; a seer, wise, omnipresent, self-existent, he disposed all things rightly for eternal years.

All who worship what is not real knowledge (good works), enter into blind darkness: those who delight in real knowledge, enter, as it were, into greater darkness.

One thing, they say, is obtained from real knowledge; another, they say, from what is not knowledge. Thus we have heard from the wise who taught us this.

He who knows at the same time both knowledge and not-knowledge, overcomes death through not-knowledge, and obtains immortality through knowledge.

All who worship what is not the true cause,
enter into blind darkness: those who delight in the true cause, enter, as it were, into greater darkness.

One thing, they say, is obtained from (knowledge of) the cause; another, they say, from (knowledge of) what is not the cause. Thus, we have heard from the wise who taught us this.

He who knows at the same time both the cause and the destruction (the perishable body), overcomes death by destruction (the perishable body), and obtains immortality through (knowledge of) the true cause.

Access reading here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/sbe01/sbe01243.htm>

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2.3: Chandogya Upanishad

Reading Three: Chandogya Upanishad (Ch. 6, Khandas: 1, 12, 13)

The Chandogya Upanishad is one of the most famous and often-read Upanishads. It tells the story of a father teaching his son the ultimate truth of Hinduism. In the beginning of the Upanishad, the father sends the boy away to study the Vedas with a religious instructor. This was a common practice among the Brahmin caste. It takes the boy 12 years to study the Vedas! When he returns home, his father apparently thinks that he is too full of himself because he believes that the Vedas (the most sacred Hindu scriptures) tell everything that needs to be known about Hinduism. But the father decides to teach his son that there is more to Hinduism – there is a mystical knowledge as well that cannot come from reading scriptures alone. The Upanishads, ironically, emphasize this theme over and over again – in a work of scripture the stories keep repeating that religion is more than just scripture!

The father then teaches the boy about the underlying unity of everything in the world. He uses examples of several different elements – clay, gold, iron – to demonstrate this point. He says that if you know one item of these elements you know them all, because underneath all their differences, they are all the same. In Hinduism, the same is true for everything in the world – there are differences, but they are only superficial. Since everything has the divine essence within it, everything is actually Brahman, and all is one.

In the next section the father uses a few experiments with a seed and salt to teach his son about the “Self” and “subtle essence” of the whole world. The father is connecting the Hindu concept of “Brahman”, “Truth,” or in western terms, God, that pervades the entire universe, and the “atman”, or personal soul that we each have within us. In Hinduism, the two are one and the same – our personal soul is divine, our divine spark, that is made of the same essence as God. This teaching is summarized in his repeated phrase to his son “thou art That” – you are Brahman.

Chandogya Upanishad

There lived once a boy named Svetaketu Āruneya. To him his father said: 'Svetaketu, go to school; for there is none belonging to our caste, darling, who, not having studied (the Vedas), is, as it were, a Brahmin by birth only.'

Having begun his apprenticeship (with a teacher) when he was twelve years of age Svetaketu returned to his father when he was twenty-four, having then studied all the Vedas,--conceited, considering himself well-read, and stern.

His father said to him: 'Svetaketu, as you are so conceited, considering yourself so well-read, and so stern, my dear, have you ever asked for that instruction by which we hear what cannot be heard, by which we perceive what cannot be perceived, by which we know what cannot be known?'

'What is that instruction, Sir?' he asked.

The father replied: 'My dear, as by one clod of clay all that is made of clay is known, the difference being only a name, arising from speech, but the truth being that all is clay;

'And as, my dear, by one nugget of gold

all that is made of gold is known, the difference being only a name, arising from speech, but the truth being that all is gold?

'And as, my dear, by one pair of nail-scissors all that is made of iron is known, the difference being only a name, arising from speech, but the truth being that all is iron,--thus, my dear, is that instruction.'

The son said: 'Surely those venerable men (my teachers) did not know that. For if they had known it, why should they not have told it me? Do you, Sir, therefore tell me that.' 'Be it so,' said the father.

'Fetch me from thence a fruit of the Nyagrodha tree.'

'Here is one, Sir.' Break it.'

'It is broken, Sir.'

'What do you see there?'

'These seeds, almost infinitesimal.'

'Break one of them.'

'It is broken, Sir.'

'What do you see there?'

'Not anything, Sir.'

The father said: 'My son, that subtle essence which you do not see there, of that very essence this great Nyagrodha tree exists.

'Believe it, my son. That which is the subtle essence, in it all that exists has its self. It is the True. It is the Self, and thou, O Svetaketu, art That.'

'Please, Sir, inform me still more,' said the son.

'Be it so, my child,' the father replied.

. 'Place this salt in water, and then bring it to me in the morning.'

The son did as he was commanded.

The father said to him: 'Bring me the salt, which you placed in the water last night.'

The son having looked for it, found it not, for, of course, it was dissolved.

The father said: 'Taste it from the surface of the water. How is it?'

The son replied: 'It is salty.'

'Taste it from the middle. How is it?'

The son replied: 'It is salty.'

'Taste it from the bottom. How is it?'

The son replied 'It is salty.'

The father said 'Throw it away and then come back to me.'

He did so; but salt exists for ever.

Then the father said: 'Here also, in this body, forsooth, you do not perceive the True (Sat), my son; but there indeed it is.

'That which is the subtle essence, in it all that exists has its self. It is the True. It is the Self, and thou, O Svetaketu, art That.'

Access the reading here:

- Khanda 1: <https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/sbe01/sbe01119.htm>
- Khanda 12: <https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/sbe01/sbe01130.htm>
- Khanda 13: <https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/sbe01/sbe01131.htm>

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2.4: Bhagavad Gita

Reading Four: Bhagavad Gita (Chapter 2, Verses 4-30)

In this section near the beginning of the Bhagavad Gita, we enter into the conversation between Arjuna and Krishna. Arjuna, a soldier, feels hesitation before a battle in the civil war between the Pandavas and the Kauravas. He does not want to have to kill people he knows, even though he knows that they are in the wrong for starting this war. He tells Krishna that he will not fight that day.

What follows is Krishna's response. Krishna is a god who has disguised himself as Arjuna's driver in order to help save humanity from the disastrous consequences of this war. He encourages Arjuna to fight because it is important that the war come to a resolution so that the fighting will stop. It is Arjuna's duty (or Dharma) to fight because that is his role in society, and the violent Kauravas must be stopped so that the country can be at peace again.

But he also justifies fighting in the war by teaching Arjuna about the difference between the soul (atman) and the physical body. They are different and separate from each other. The soul is eternal while the body is temporary. He says that this is important for a warrior to understand because he's not really killing his enemies on the battlefield – he is only killing their bodies and their souls will live on, reincarnating back into the world. (In this story, Arjuna is the good guy and those he will fight are the bad guys). Krishna says that we have always existed and will always exist, because our souls are eternal – our physical bodies and lives are just temporary.

So we should do what is right, what our society needs of us, focusing on our soul and not our physical body.

Bhagavad Gita Excerpt

Arjuna said: How shall I strike my grandfather, my guru, and all other relatives, who are worthy of my respect, with arrows in battle, O Krishna?

It would be better, indeed, to live on alms in this world than to slay these noble personalities, because by killing them I would enjoy wealth and pleasures stained with their blood.

We do not know which alternative, to fight or to quit, is better for us. Further, we do not know whether we shall conquer them or they will conquer us. We should not even wish to live after killing our cousin brothers, who are standing in front of us.

My senses are overcome by the weakness of pity, and my mind is confused about duty (Dharma). Please tell me what is better for me. I am Your disciple, and I take refuge in You.

I do not perceive that gaining an unrivaled and prosperous kingdom on this earth, or even lordship over all the celestial controllers will remove the sorrow that is drying up my senses.

After speaking like this to Lord Krishna, the mighty Arjuna said to Krishna: I shall not fight, and became silent.

O King, Lord Krishna, as if smiling, spoke these words to the distressed Arjuna in the midst of the two armies.

Lord Krishna said: You grieve for those who are not worthy of grief, and yet speak words of wisdom. The wise grieves neither for the living nor for the dead.

There was never a time when these monarchs, you, or I did not exist; nor shall we ever cease to exist in the future.

Just as the soul acquires a childhood body, a youth body, and an old age body during this life; similarly, the soul acquires another body after death. This should not delude the wise.

The contacts of the senses with the sense objects give rise to the feelings of heat and cold, and pain and pleasure. They are transitory and impermanent. Therefore, one should learn to endure them. Because a calm person who is not afflicted by these sense objects, and is steady in pain and pleasure becomes fit for salvation.

The invisible Spirit (Atma, Atman) is eternal, and the visible physical body, is transitory. The reality of these two is indeed certainly seen by the seers of truth.

The Spirit by whom this entire universe is pervaded is indestructible. No one can destroy the imperishable Spirit.

The physical bodies of the eternal, immutable, and incomprehensible Spirit are perishable. Therefore fight, O Arjuna.

The one who thinks that the Spirit is a killer, and the one who thinks the Spirit is killed, both are ignorant. Because the Spirit neither kills nor is killed.

The Spirit is neither born nor does it die at any time. It does not come into being, or cease to exist. It is unborn, eternal, permanent, and primeval. The Spirit is not destroyed when the body is destroyed.

O Arjuna, how can a person who knows that the Spirit is indestructible, eternal, unborn, and immutable, kill anyone or causes anyone to be killed?

Just as a person puts on new garments after discarding the old ones; similarly, the living entity or the individual soul acquires new bodies after casting away the old bodies.

Weapons do not cut this Spirit, fire does not burn it, water does not make it wet, and the wind does not make it dry. The Spirit cannot be cut, burned, wetted, or dried. It is eternal, all pervading, unchanging, immovable, and primeval.

The Spirit is said to be unexplainable, incomprehensible, and unchanging. Knowing the Spirit as such you should not grieve.

Even if you think that the physical body takes birth and dies perpetually, even then, O Arjuna, you should not grieve like this. Because death is certain for the one who is born, and birth is certain for the one who dies. Therefore, you should not lament over the inevitable.

All beings are unmanifest, or invisible to our physical eyes before birth and after death. They manifest between the birth and the death only. What is there to grieve about?

Some look upon this Spirit as a wonder, another describes it as wonderful, and others hear of it as a wonder. Even after hearing about it very few people know what the Spirit is.

O Arjuna, the Spirit that dwells in the body of all beings is eternally indestructible. Therefore, you should not mourn for anybody.

Access the reading here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/gita/agsgita.htm>

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Buddhist Scriptures

[3.1: The Life of the Buddha - Buddha's Escape from his life of Luxury](#)

[3.2: The Dhammapada Lecture One](#)

[3.3: The Heart Sutra](#)

Thumbnail: Ancient style of scripture of the Pali Canon. In ancient times the Pali Canon was not published in book form, but written on thin slices of wood (possibly bamboo). These 'pages' are kept on top of each other by thin sticks, which go through two little holes in scripture. When not used, the scripture is covered in cloth and kept in a box. (CC BY-SA 2.5 Generic; DhJ via [Wikipedia](#))

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3.1: The Life of the Buddha - Buddha's Escape from his life of Luxury

Reading One: The Life of the Buddha: Buddha's Escape from his life of Luxury

The life story of the Buddha is an incredibly important myth throughout the Buddhist world. It is a story that was told orally for hundreds of years before it was ever written down, and there are many different written versions of the story written in various languages over the history of Buddhism. So there is no single definitive version of the story, though all the versions share the same general outline: Siddhartha Gautama is born a wealthy prince and kept in a palace of pleasure and luxury by his father to keep him from becoming disillusioned from the world. But when Siddhartha is a young man, he finally witnesses the truth of old age, sickness, and death and is so despondent that he leaves his home and family (he is married with a baby now) in order to become a monk and find enlightenment. He eventually does, becoming the Buddha after several years of trial and error in seeking the truth of the world and how to overcome suffering.

The following excerpt tells the part of the story after Siddhartha has seen an old man, a sick man, and a corpse and finally learned the truth of suffering in the world. He can no longer find joy in his palace or family and comes to the decision that he must run away and become a homeless monk in order to find peace.

The Life of the Buddha

Siddhartha could no longer find peace. He strode through the halls of his palace like a lion stung by some poisoned dart. He was unhappy.

One day, there came to him a great longing for the open fields and the sight of green meadows. He left the palace, and as he strolled aimlessly through the country, he mused:

"It is indeed a pity that man, weak as he really is, and subject to sickness, with old age a certainty and death for a master, should, in his ignorance and pride, condemn the sick, the aged and the dead. If I should look with disgust upon some fellow-being who was sick or old or dead, I would be unjust, I would not be worthy of understanding the supreme law."

And as he pondered the misery of mankind, he lost the vain illusion of strength, of youth and of life. He knew no longer joy or grief, doubt or weariness, desire or love, hatred or scorn.

Suddenly, he saw a man approaching who looked like a beggar and who was visible to him alone.

"Tell me, who are you?" the prince asked him.

"Hero," said the monk, "through fear of birth and death, I became an itinerant monk. I seek deliverance. The world is at the mercy of destruction. I think not as other men; I shun pleasures; I know nothing of passion; I look for solitude. Sometimes I live at the foot of a tree; sometimes I live in the lonely mountains or sometimes in the forest. I own nothing; I expect nothing. I wander about, living on charity, and seeking only the highest good."

Siddhartha was happy. He saw where his duty lay; he decided to leave the palace and become a monk.

He returned to the city. Near the gates he passed a young woman who bowed and said to him, "She who is your bride must know supreme blessedness, O noble prince." He heard her voice, and his soul was filled with peace: the thought had come to him of supreme blessedness, of beatitude, of nirvana.

He went to the king; he bowed and said to him:

"King, grant the request I have to make. Do not oppose it, for I am determined. I would leave the palace, I would walk in the path of deliverance. We must part, father."

The king was deeply moved. With tears in his voice, he said to his son:

"Son, give up this idea. You're still too young to consider a religious calling. Our thoughts in the springtime of life are wayward and changeable. Besides, it is a grave mistake to perform austere practices in our youth. Our senses are eager for new pleasures; our firmest resolutions are forgotten when we learn the cost in effort. The body wanders in the forest of desire, only our thoughts escape. Youth lacks experience. It is for me, rather, to embrace religion. The time has come for me to leave the palace. I abdicate, O my son. Reign in my stead. Be strong and courageous; your family needs you. And first know the joys of youth, then those of later years, before you betake yourself to the woods and become a hermit."

The prince answered:

"Promise me four things, O father, and I shall not leave your house and repair to the woods."

"What are they?" asked the king.

"Promise me that my life will not end in death, that sickness will not impair my health, that age will not follow my youth, that misfortune will not destroy my prosperity."

"You are asking too much," replied the king. "Give up this idea. It is not well to act on a foolish impulse."

Solemn as Meru mountain, the prince said to his father:

"If you cannot promise me these four things, do not hold me back, O father. When someone is trying to escape from a burning house, we should not hinder him. The day comes, inevitably, when we must leave this world, but what merits is there in a forced separation? A voluntary separation is far better. Death would carry me out of the world before I had reached my goal, before I had satisfied my ardor. The world is a prison: would that I could free those beings who are prisoners of desire! The world is a deep pit wherein wander the ignorant and the blind: would that I could light the lamp of knowledge, would that I could remove the film that hides the light of wisdom! The world has raised the wrong banner, it has raised the banner of pride: would that I could pull it down, would that I could tear to pieces the banner of pride! The world is troubled, the world is in a turmoil, the world is a wheel of fire: would that I could, with the true law, bring peace to all men!"

Access the original reading here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/bud/lob/lob13.htm>

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3.2: The Dhammapada Lecture One

Reading Two: The Dhammapada Lecture One

This is the very first lecture from the Dhammapada, which is a collection of sermons or lectures that are believed to have been spoken directly by the Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama.

This section is known as the “Twin Verses” because of the style of coupling the phrases – as you can see the Buddha goes back and forth between discussing enlightened and unenlightened people and their corresponding attitudes and actions. The style may seem a bit repetitive because every two lines are almost exactly the same, except one line describes the virtuous or enlightened individual, and the other the not virtuous or enlightened individual.

The lecture focuses on how powerful our thoughts are, which is a major teaching of Buddhism. If we want to change the way we interact with the world, we must first learn to analyze our own thoughts, positive or negative, to see how they impact our actions. If we want to lead virtuous, joyful lives we have to begin with virtuous, joyful thoughts. Then our joy and peace will continue because of the virtuous actions we have taken towards others.

The “yellow robe” that is mentioned in the middle of the passage is referring to the robes that Buddhist monks and nuns wear, and the “law” in the final verses is referring to the “dharma” or Buddhist teachings.

Dhammapada Lecture One

All that we are is the result of what we have thought: it is founded on our thoughts, it is made up of our thoughts. If a man speaks or acts with an evil thought, pain follows him, as the wheel follows the foot of the ox that draws the carriage.

All that we are is the result of what we have thought: it is founded on our thoughts, it is made up of our thoughts. If a man speaks or acts with a pure thought, happiness follows him, like a shadow that never leaves him.

'He abused me, he beat me, he defeated me, he robbed me,'--in those who harbour such thoughts hatred will never cease.

'He abused me, he beat me, he defeated me, he robbed me,'--in those who do not harbour such thoughts hatred will cease.

For hatred does not cease by hatred at any time: hatred ceases by love, this is an old rule.

The world does not know that we must all come to an end here;--but those who know it, their quarrels cease at once.

He who lives looking for pleasures only, his senses uncontrolled, immoderate in his food, idle, and weak, Mâra (the tempter) will certainly overthrow him, as the wind throws down a weak tree.

He who lives without looking for pleasures, his senses well controlled, moderate in his food, faithful and strong, him Mâra will certainly not overthrow, any more than the wind throws down a rocky mountain.

He who wishes to put on the yellow dress without having cleansed himself from sin, who disregards temperance and truth, is unworthy of the yellow dress.

But he who has cleansed himself from sin, is well grounded in all virtues, and regards also temperance and truth, he is indeed worthy of the yellow dress.

They who imagine truth in untruth, and see untruth in truth, never arrive at truth, but follow vain desires.

They who know truth in truth, and untruth in untruth, arrive at truth, and follow true desires.

As rain breaks through an ill-thatched house, passion will break through an unreflecting mind.

As rain does not break through a well-thatched house, passion will not break through a well-reflecting mind.

The evil-doer mourns in this world, and he mourns in the next; he mourns in both. He mourns and suffers when he sees the evil of his own work.

The virtuous man delights in this world, and he delights in the next; he delights in both. He delights and rejoices, when he sees the purity of his own work.

The evil-doer suffers in this world, and he suffers in the next; he suffers in both. He suffers when he thinks of the evil he has done; he suffers more when going on the evil path.

The virtuous man is happy in this world, and he is happy in the next; he is happy in both. He is happy when he thinks of the good he has done; he is still more happy when going on the good path.

The thoughtless man, even if he can recite a large portion (of the law), but is not a doer of it, has no share in the priesthood, but is like a cowherd counting the cows of others.

The follower of the law, even if he can recite only a small portion (of the law), but, having forsaken passion and hatred and foolishness, possesses true knowledge and serenity of mind, he, caring for nothing in this world or that to come, has indeed a share in the priesthood.

Access the original text here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/bud/sbe10/sbe1003.htm>

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3.3: The Heart Sutra

Reading Three: The Heart Sutra

The Heart Sutra is a short passage that, though quite complicated in its philosophy, has become one of the most beloved and often chanted passages in the Buddhist world, especially Mahayana Buddhism.

The main theme of the passage is “anatta,” which translates to emptiness. Buddhists believe in a doctrine sometimes called “interdependent origination,” which teaches that nothing in this world has an independent, stable essence. Everything that exists in this world – us, the natural world, all living beings, all thoughts, ideas, feelings, events, etc. – exist in a web of cause and effect. Everything, including ourselves, is interdependent, not independent. This is a complex doctrine and Buddhists spend their entire lives trying to better understand it.

So Buddhists claim that because everything exists only in connection to everything else, that means that everything is “empty”, meaning that it has no independent, stable essence to it. There is nothing that exists independently in and of itself.

We can see this teaching in the first section of The Heart Sutra. Avalokiteshvara is a bodhisattva, or an enlightened being, and in the beginning of this passage we can see him becoming enlightened when he “suddenly discovered” this truth and then tries to teach it to “Sariputra,” another Buddhist monk.

So Avalokiteshvara is encouraging Sariputra to reject “dualism,” which is the belief that there are two essential natures that exist in the world. In other words, that world is a place of opposites – some might say a place of good and evil. But Buddhism rejects all that and says that what we think of as opposites are not really opposite. If everything is interdependent, then even opposites depend upon each other.

The passage uses the examples of our bodies and what are called the “five skandhas” in Buddhism, which are our “feelings, perceptions, mental formations, and consciousness”. These five, along with the body, are what constitutes a human being in Buddhism. The passage discusses the “emptiness” of all of these, as well as the emptiness of “all phenomena”, which also means that they are not “separate self entities”, meaning that they are interdependent, and not separate.

The Sutra also contains a list of pairs of opposites and says that they don’t exist – there is ‘no birth no death, no being no non-being’ etc. This is the rejection of dualism and opposites – Buddhists encourage meditation on phrases such as this to better understand the reality of the world. There is “no birth” and “no death” because in Buddhism we have always existed in some form in the world and probably will for a very long time before we reach Nirvana. We come back and exist in this world in a variety of forms; therefore our “birth” is not really our birth, it was just our re-entering into this world in our current form, and our “death” is not really our death, just a transition to another form in this world.

There may still be some confusing parts of this passage, and that is okay! As I said before, this passage is one that Buddhists meditate on and try to come to a better understanding of because it presents, in a very condensed format, an extremely complicated Buddhist doctrine.

The Heart Sutra

Avalokiteshvara, while practicing deeply with the Insight that Brings Us to the Other Shore, suddenly discovered that all of the five Skandhas are equally empty, and with this realization he overcame all Ill-being.

“Listen Sariputra, this Body itself is Emptiness and Emptiness itself is this Body. This body is not other than Emptiness and Emptiness is not other than this Body. The same is true of Feelings, Perceptions, Mental Formations, and Consciousness.

“Listen Sariputra, all phenomena bear the mark of Emptiness; their true nature is the nature of no Birth no Death, no Being no Non-being, no Defilement no Purity, no Increasing no Decreasing.

“That is why Emptiness, Body, Feelings, Perceptions, Mental Formations and Consciousness are not separate self-entities...

Ill-being, the causes of ill-being, the end of ill-being, the Path, insight and attainment, are also not separate self-entities.

Whoever can see this no longer needs anything to attain.

Bodhisattvas who practice the Insight that Brings Us to the Other Shore see no more obstacles in their mind, they can overcome all fear, destroy all wrong perceptions and realize Perfect Nirvana.

All Buddhas in the past, present and future by practicing the Insight that Brings Us to the Other Shore are all capable of attaining Authentic and Perfect Enlightenment.

Access the original reading here:

<https://1gkys61108am2vvslv1ayriu-wpengine.netdna-ssl.com/wp-content/uploads/2014/09/2014-Thich-Nhat-Hanh-New-Heart-Sutra-letter-cc.pdf>

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Jewish Scriptures

4.1: Bereshit – The Opening of the Torah

4.2: Moshe is Called by God

4.3: Talmud

4.4: Kabbalah

Thumbnail: Old scrolls Menorah. (Unsplash License; [Diana Polekhina](#) via [Unsplash](#))

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4.1: Bereshit – The Opening of the Torah

Reading One: Bereshit (1:1-3) – The Opening of the Torah

This reading gives the two stories of creation from the Jewish sacred text, the Tanakh. This section is divided up into two quite different versions of the creation of the world and the first human beings. If students are familiar with this text via the Christian tradition, it is important to remember that the Jewish version is a bit different, as it is often translated differently. The first difference to note is that the word Adam (adham) is not a proper name, as it is commonly assumed to be in Christian culture. The word adham in Hebrew simply means earth-creature so it means human in general, and is not a proper name.

Secondly, there are two stories here. The first account of creation goes from Genesis 1:1 up to 2:3. Then in Genesis 2:4 a second creation story starts, which retells the story, but this time a bit differently,

The main differences between the two include the style and tone of the writing, descriptions of God (Elohim or Adonai in Hebrew) and the order of creation. Note when Adam and Eve (Ishah in Hebrew) are created in each story. Note also that the story of the Garden of Eden and the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil are only mentioned in the second story.

The first story of creation (Gen. 1:1-2:3) is highly organized and structured – all of creation happens over the course of six days and then God rests on the seventh day. Man and woman are created at the same time, and are the very last act of creation – the whole earth is prepared for their arrival. God also appears to be more of a spirit or powerful force, with no human-like characteristics.

The second story of creation (Gen. 2:4-2:25) begins right in the middle of creation in the Garden of Eden (no specific location is mentioned in the first story). Adam and the earth are already there, but no Eve or plants or animals. God then goes about creating all these things so the earth is fully created, but there is still no Eve. At this point God then decides to give Adam specific instructions about not eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. After Eve is created to be Adam's "helper," the two end up eating from the tree and receiving punishment, including banishment from the Garden.

Notice the two stories and how they are similar and different from each other.

Genesis

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. Now the earth was unformed and void, and darkness was upon the face of the deep; and the spirit of God hovered over the face of the waters. And there was light. And God saw the light, that it was good; and God divided the light from the darkness. And God called the light /day, and the darkness He called Night. And there was evening and there was morning, one day.

And God said: 'Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.' And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the waters which were above the firmament; and it was so. And God called the firmament Heaven. And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

And God said: 'Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land appear.' And it was so. And God called the dry land Earth, and the gathering together of the waters called He Seas; and God saw that it was good. And God said: 'Let the earth put forth grass, herb yielding seed, and fruit-tree bearing fruit after its kind, wherein is the seed thereof, upon the earth.' And it was so. And the earth brought forth grass, herb yielding seed after its kind, and tree bearing fruit, wherein is the seed thereof, after its kind; and God saw that it was good. And there was evening and there was morning, a third day.

And God said: 'Let there be lights in the firmament of the heaven to divide the day from the night; and let them be for signs, and for seasons, and for days and years; and let them be for lights in the firmament of the heaven to give light upon the earth.' And it was so. And God made the two great lights: the greater light to rule the day, and the lesser light to rule the night; and the stars. And God set them in the firmament of the heaven to give light upon the earth, and to rule over the day and over the night, and to divide the light from the darkness; and God saw that it was good. And there was evening and there was morning, a fourth day.

And God said: 'Let the waters swarm with swarms of living creatures, and let fowl fly above the earth in the open firmament of heaven. And God created the great sea-monsters, and every living creature that creepeth, wherewith the waters swarmed, after its kind, and every winged fowl after its kind; and God saw that it was good. And God blessed them, saying: 'Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the waters in the seas, and let fowl multiply in the earth.' And there was evening and there was morning, a fifth day.

And God said: 'Let the earth bring forth the living creatures after its kind, cattle, and creeping thing, and best of the earth after its kind, and the cattle after their kind, and every thing that creepeth upon the ground after its kind; and God saw that it was good. And

God said: 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness; and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creepeth upon the earth.' And God created man in His own image, in the image of God created He him; male and female created he them. And God blessed them; and God said unto them: 'Be fruitful, and multiply, and replenish the earth, and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over every living thing that creepeth upon the earth.' And God said: 'Behold, I have given you every herb yielding seed, which is upon the face of all the earth, and every tree, in which is the fruit of a tree yielding seed – to you it shall be for food; and to every beast of the earth, and to every fowl of the air, and to every thing that creepeth upon the earth, wherein there is a living soul, I have given every green herb for food.' And it was so. And God saw every thing that He had made and, behold, it was very good. And there was evening and there was morning, the sixth day.

And the heaven and the earth were finished, and all the host of them. And on the seventh day God finished His work which He had made; and He rested on the seventh day from all His work which He had made. And God blessed the seventh day and hallowed it; because that in it He rested from all His work which God in creating had made. These are the generations of the heaven and of the earth which they were created, in the day that the Lord God made earth and heaven. (*end of first creation myth)

Access the text located here:

- <https://opensiddur.org/readings-and-sourcetexts/mekorot/tanakh/translations/tanakh-the-holy-scriptures-a-new-translation-jps-1917/>

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4.2: Moshe is Called by God

Moshe is Called by God – Shemot (Exodus) 2-3

The following reading is from the second book of the Torah, Exodus, or in Hebrew Shemot. This book tells the story of the Hebrews enslavement in Egypt and how God liberates them and leads them out of Egypt. This is a story that may be familiar to many of you, as it is also part of the Christian Bible and has recently been made into two popular Hollywood films. In this section we are introduced to Moshe (Moses in Christian Bibles) and told how God picks him to be the leader who will free the Hebrews from Pharaoh.

Moshe occupies an interesting place in Egyptian society because he is Hebrew but raised in the Pharaoh's palace by Pharaoh's daughter, making the Pharaoh his own stepfather, in a way. We then learn how Moshe murders an Egyptian man who strikes a Hebrew slave – when the Pharaoh tries to have him killed, he runs away to a land called Midyan. There he finds a wife and seems happy and content as a herder, but God appears to him and asks him to lead the Hebrews out of slavery.

As you read this section, note the strong themes of immigration and feeling like an outsider – Moshe grows up as a Hebrew surrounded by Egyptians. He must have felt out of place and different in his own family. Then he flees to Midyan and is also an outsider there. When God speaks to him he doesn't feel confident that the Hebrew leaders will listen to him, possibly because he didn't grow up among them, so they might not consider him to be truly a Hebrew. This is also the section of the Torah when we learn what God's proper name is.

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4.3: Talmud

Reading Three: Talmud: Treatise 12 (The Fathers), Chapter Six

One of the main themes of the Talmud is praise for studying the Torah and Halakha, which are both often called the “law” in the Talmud. So this section discusses how great and blessed is the man who studies the Torah.

This section focuses on all the qualities of the man who studies the law and how much it will benefit his life. At the beginning of the passage it mentioned the “Mishna” which is the oldest portion of commentary on the Torah. The Mishna is one part of the commentary (with the Gemara being the other) that is collected into the Talmud.

The passage also mentions several rabbis (that’s what the R. stands for): Rabbi Meier and Rabbi Joshua. This is typical of the Talmud, which brings together around a single topic hundreds of years of writing/opinions of revered Jewish scholars. The passage also includes a few sentences discussing King David, a figure from the Tanakh, and his behavior towards a man who taught him about God’s law. This is also very typical of the Talmud – it will recount a passage from the Tanakh and then discuss what it should mean for our behavior today. So just as David, a King, treated a man with lower social standing than him with respect for teaching him, we should be very respectful to anyone who teaches us about God’s law.

Treatise 12: The Fathers, Chapter Six

The sages studied in the language of the Mishna; blessed be He who made a choice of them and their learning. R. Meier said, “he who is engaged in the study of the law for its own sake merits many things, and not only so, but the whole world is under the greatest obligation to him; he is called a dear friend, dear to God and dear to mankind; he rejoices God and rejoices his creatures. It clothes him with meekness and the fear of God, and directs him to become just, pious, righteous, and faithful; it removes him from sin, and brings him near to merit, and the world is benefited by his counsel, sound wisdom, understanding, and strength; as is said, “Counsel is mine, and sound wisdom; I am understanding, I have strength.” ² It also bestows on him empire, dominion, and perception in judgment. It reveals the secrets of the law to him, and he shall be an increasing fountain, and a never-failing river; and it will cause him to be modest, slow to anger, and ready to pardon an injury done to him; and it will magnify and exalt him above all things...

He who learns from his companion one chapter, sentence, verse, or expression, ought to behave towards him with respect; for thus we find by David, King of Israel, who having learned only two things from Ahitophel, called him his teacher, guide, and acquaintance, as is said, “But it was thou, a man mine equal, my guide, and mine acquaintance.” Hence it may be deduced that if David, King of Israel, who having learned only two things from Ahitophel, called him his “teacher, guide, and acquaintance,” how much more ought he who learns from his companion a single chapter, sentence, verse, or expression, to show him the utmost respect? And there is no glory but the knowledge of the law; as is said, “The wise shall inherit glory;” and the perfect shall inherit the good; but nothing is really good but the law, as is said, “For I give you good doctrine, forsake ye not my law.”

Access the text here:

<https://www.sacred-texts.com/jud/bar/bar094.htm>

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4.4: Kabbalah

Kabbalah refers to an ancient mystical tradition in Judaism.

Passage from Zohar, Idra Zutta (Small Assembly)

The Most Ancient One is at the same time the most Hidden of the hidden. He is separated from all things, and is at the same time not separated from all things. For all things are united in Him, and He unites Himself with all things. There is nothing which is not in Him. He has a shape, and one can say that He has not one. In assuming a shape, He has given existence to all things. He made ten lights spring forth from His midst, lights which shine with the form which they have borrowed from Him, and which shed everywhere the light of a brilliant day. The Ancient One, the most Hidden of the hidden, is a high beacon, and we know Him only by His lights, which illuminate our eyes so abundantly. His Holy Name is no other thing than these lights.

Access the text here:

https://www.sacred-texts.com/jud/jm/jm11.htm#fn_8

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Christian Scriptures

[5.1: The Beatitudes](#)

[5.2: Resurrection of Jesus](#)

[5.3: Paul's Discourse on Love](#)

[5.4: Book of Revelations](#)

Thumbnail: An old Martin Luther bible (Unsplash License; [Kiwihug](#) via [Unsplash](#))

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5.1: The Beatitudes

The Beatitudes from the Gospel of Matthew (Matthew 5:1-45)

The following passage is the most famous teaching that Jesus gave – it is only recorded in the Gospel of Matthew and is commonly known as “The Beatitudes” or the “Sermon on the Mount” because Jesus walks onto a small hill in order to give this speech as Matthew relates that a crowd had gathered to hear him. It is in this sermon that Jesus gives some of his most iconic teachings, such as the teaching to love one’s enemies, shun worldly wealth and practice mercy and extreme charity. As you will see in this section, Jesus teaches a form of radical ethics – what he asks of his followers is a very difficult lifestyle: one that embraces pacifism, poverty, and selfless giving of oneself.

As this long speech is only recorded in the Gospel of Matthew, scholars believe that it likely did not occur in a single sermon – most likely this is a collection of teachings of Jesus that Matthew recorded in this gospel and condensed them into a single speech in order to create a parallel between Jesus and Moses. Matthew is commonly considered the most “Jewish” Gospel and that Matthew describes Jesus as a kind of ‘new Moses.’ By having Jesus give this ethical teaching on a “mount,” he is recreating the scene from the Hebrew Bible in which Moses stands over the Hebrews and teaches them the Law that God has dictated to him.

The Sermon on the Mount

Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven.

Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.

Blessed are the gentle, for they shall inherit the earth.

Blessed are those who hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled.

Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy.

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God.

Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called children of God.

Blessed are those who have been persecuted for righteousness’ sake, for theirs is the Kingdom of Heaven...

You have heard that it was said to the ancient ones, ‘You shall not murder;’ and ‘Whoever shall murder shall be in danger of the judgment.’

But I tell you, that everyone who is angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment; and whoever shall say to his brother, ‘Raca!’ shall be in danger of the council; and whoever shall say, ‘You fool!’ shall be in danger of the fire of Gehenna.

“If therefore you are offering your gift at the altar, and there remember that your brother has anything against you, leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift...

“You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall not commit adultery;’

but I tell you that everyone who gazes at a woman to lust after her has committed adultery with her already in his heart.

“You have heard that it was said, ‘An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth.’

But I tell you, don’t resist him who is evil; but whoever strikes you on your right cheek, turn to him the other also.

If anyone sues you to take away your coat, let him have your cloak also.

Whoever compels you to go one mile, go with him two.

Give to him who asks you, and don’t turn away him who desires to borrow from you.

“You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall love your neighbor, and hate your enemy.’

But I tell you, love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who mistreat you and persecute you,

that you may be children of your Father who is in heaven. For he makes his sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the just and the unjust.

Access the text here:

- <https://www.sacred-texts.com/bib/web/mat.htm>

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5.2: Resurrection of Jesus

Resurrection of Jesus (the two endings of Mark)

Jesus is sentenced to death by the Roman authorities and executed by crucifixion. After his body is buried in a nearby tomb and a stone rolled in front of the opening, Christians believe that Jesus resurrected from the dead and appeared to several of his followers. The following is the story of the resurrection as told in the Gospel of Mark. There are two versions of the ending of Mark, which discusses the resurrection. The earlier/shorter version below is Mark 16:1-9; all of the earliest Greek copies of the Gospel of Mark that we have end after verse 9. In this ending, two female followers of Jesus (both are named Mary) come to anoint Jesus' body but instead of finding the corpse they found that the stone covering the entrance of the tomb had been rolled away and a "young man" was sitting inside the tomb. This young man told them that Jesus had risen from the dead and they should go tell his other followers that Jesus will appear in Galilee. But in this version of the story, the two women are so afraid that they simply run away and don't tell anyone!

The later/longer version of the ending adds several verses onto the first ending, specifically verses 9-20. You can see a disruption in the text as verse 9 starts with "now when he had risen" and then actually changes the story – in this version Jesus *does* appear to Mary Magdalene, and then she goes and tells the disciples, but they don't believe her. So this second ending is very different from the first! In the longer version, Jesus then does appear to several of his followers, though many don't believe until he appears personally to them.

Earlier/Shorter Ending of Mark:

When the Sabbath was past, Mary Magdalene, and Mary the mother of James, and Salome, bought spices, that they might come and anoint him.

Very early on the first day of the week, they came to the tomb when the sun had risen.

They were saying among themselves, "Who will roll away the stone from the door of the tomb for us?"

for it was very big. Looking up, they saw that the stone was rolled back.

Entering into the tomb, they saw a young man sitting on the right side, dressed in a white robe, and they were amazed.

He said to them, "Don't be amazed. You seek Jesus, the Nazarene, who has been crucified. He has risen. He is not here. Behold, the place where they laid him!

But go, tell his disciples and Peter, 'He goes before you into Galilee. There you will see him, as he said to you.'"

They went out, and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had come on them. They said nothing to anyone; for they were afraid.

Later/Longer Ending of Mark:

Now when he had risen early on the first day of the week, he appeared first to Mary Magdalene, from whom he had cast out seven demons.

She went and told those who had been with him, as they mourned and wept.

When they heard that he was alive, and had been seen by her, they disbelieved.

After these things he was revealed in another form to two of them, as they walked, on their way into the country.

They went away and told it to the rest. They didn't believe them, either.

Afterward he was revealed to the eleven themselves as they sat at the table, and he rebuked them for their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they didn't believe those who had seen him after he had risen.

He said to them, "Go into all the world, and preach the Good News to the whole creation.

He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who disbelieves will be condemned.

These signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new languages; they will take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it will in no way hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover."

So then the Lord, after he had spoken to them, was received up into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of God.

They went out, and preached everywhere, the Lord working with them, and confirming the word by the signs that followed. Amen.

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- <https://www.sacred-texts.com/bib/web/mar.htm>

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5.3: Paul's Discourse on Love

Paul's Discourse on Love (1 Corinthians 13:1-13)

The following is from the section of the New Testament known as the Epistles, which is simply a fancy word for “letter”. It is written by a man named Paul, who was the most successful Christian missionary of the first century CE. Paul’s original name was Saul, and he was a Jewish man who hated and persecuted Christians after Jesus’ death when the new religion began. However, when he was about 30 years old (around 33-36CE) he had a vision of Jesus Christ that convinced him to join the Christian religion spread it to others around the Mediterranean. Saul changed his name to Paul to symbolize that he was a new person after converting to Christianity. Paul evangelized and set up many church communities all around Israel/Palestine and beyond. He traveled often and so would write letters to the various church communities he established when he was away from them. These letters usually follow a similar pattern: Paul starts by sending greetings and well wishes to everyone, and sometimes specific individuals. Then he either answers questions that they must have sent to him in a letter or responds to accusations of incorrect teachings or practices. So a major purpose of the letters is instructional – Paul has heard that there is some sort of issue in the church community – this could be disagreements among the members or teachings/practices that are not orthodox in Paul’s view. Paul uses the letter to correct the community and give them instructions on how they should treat each other and who Jesus is and what his death means.

Paul also gives general instructions to the church communities, which is what the following passage is doing. This passage was written to a church community in Corinth and is instructing the church members on how they should treat each other and how important it is that the congregation display love towards each other. It then ends by reminding the Corinthians that we cannot know everything about God and Jesus in this life because we are mere humans. Therefore, love is always more important than knowledge and Christians should strive to love perfectly, not know anything perfectly.

The Gift of Love

If I speak with the languages of men and of angels, but don't have love, I have become sounding brass, or a clanging cymbal.

If I have the gift of prophecy, and know all mysteries and all knowledge; and if I have all faith, so as to remove mountains, but don't have love, I am nothing.

If I dole out all my goods to feed the poor, and if I give my body to be burned, but don't have love, it profits me nothing.

Love is patient and is kind; love doesn't envy. Love doesn't brag, is not proud,
doesn't behave itself inappropriately, doesn't seek its own way, is not provoked, takes no account of evil;

doesn't rejoice in unrighteousness, but rejoices with the truth;

bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.

Love never fails. But where there are prophecies, they will be done away with. Where there are various languages, they will cease.
Where there is knowledge, it will be done away with.

For we know in part, and we prophesy in part;

but when that which is complete has come, then that which is partial will be done away with.

When I was a child, I spoke as a child, I felt as a child, I thought as a child. Now that I have become a man, I have put away childish things.

For now we see in a mirror, dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in part, but then I will know fully, even as I was also fully known.

But now faith, hope, and love remain--these three. The greatest of these is love.

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5.4: Book of Revelations

Book of Revelations' description of the Antichrist (Revelation 13)

The following passage is from the Book of Revelation, which is the very last section of the Christian Bible. The book is written by a man named John who has been exiled to the Isle of Patmos for his Christian belief (remember that Christianity was still illegal when the Bible was being written). When on this island he has a mystical vision in which Jesus comes back to earth, vanquishes his enemies, gathers together all his followers, and erects a new Jerusalem. The book is highly symbolic and can be very difficult to interpret. This vision of the return of Jesus has fascinated and confused Christians since its writing. Some see the descriptions of beasts, angels, seals, trumpets, a heavenly city, etc. as literal, and others view them as symbolic. Some interpreters have seen it as a vision of the apocalypse while others have seen it as describing the fall of the Roman Empire.

Perhaps the most fascinating section of the book is the description of the “antichrist”, or beast that will rise out of the sea and trick many humans into worshipping it. Jesus Christ will eventually battle and defeat the Antichrist when he returns, which will signal the beginning of his gathering of all his true followers into an idyllic reward – living in the new Jerusalem.

The following is a description of this “antichrist” as well as a secondary beast that will assist the Antichrist in tricking people into worshipping it, when it is actually evil. Some believe that the Antichrist is the devil himself.

The Antichrist

Then I stood on the sand of the sea. I saw a beast coming up out of the sea, having ten horns and seven heads. On his horns were ten crowns, and on his heads, blasphemous names.

The beast which I saw was like a leopard, and his feet were like those of a bear, and his mouth like the mouth of a lion. The dragon gave him his power, his throne, and great authority.

One of his heads looked like it had been wounded fatally. His fatal wound was healed, and the whole earth marveled at the beast.

They worshiped the dragon, because he gave his authority to the beast, and they worshiped the beast, saying, "Who is like the beast? Who is able to make war with him?"

A mouth speaking great things and blasphemy was given to him. Authority to make war for forty-two months was given to him.

He opened his mouth for blasphemy against God, to blaspheme his name, and his dwelling, those who dwell in heaven.

It was given to him to make war with the saints, and to overcome them. Authority over every tribe, people, language, and nation was given to him.

All who dwell on the earth will worship him, everyone whose name has not been written from the foundation of the world in the book of life of the Lamb who has been killed...

I saw another beast coming up out of the earth. He had two horns like a lamb, and he spoke like a dragon.

He exercises all the authority of the first beast in his presence. He makes the earth and those who dwell in it to worship the first beast, whose fatal wound was healed.

He performs great signs, even making fire come down out of the sky to the earth in the sight of people.

He deceives my own people who dwell on the earth because of the signs he was granted to do in front of the beast; saying to those who dwell on the earth, that they should make an image to the beast who had the sword wound and lived.

It was given to him to give breath to it, to the image of the beast, that the image of the beast should both speak, and cause as many as wouldn't worship the image of the beast to be killed.

He causes all, the small and the great, the rich and the poor, and the free and the slave, to be given marks on their right hands, or on their foreheads;

and that no one would be able to buy or to sell, unless he has that mark, the name of the beast or the number of his name.

Here is wisdom. He who has understanding, let him calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man. His number is six hundred sixty-six.

Access the text here:

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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6.1: The Fatihah

The Fatihah – Opening Verses of the Quran (Surah 1)

The opening verses of the Quran are very important for Muslims because they give a description how God is understood in Islam and set down the most important themes in Muslim theology. The first words of the Fatihah, “in the name of Allah, the Gracious, the Merciful” is important because it centers all of the Muslim tradition around God (Allah is simply the Arabic word for God) and every single Surah of the Quran also starts with this short phrase. It also mentions the “Day of Judgment” which is an important theme throughout the Quran, and refers to the Muslim belief that at some point in the future, Jesus will return to earth to complete his mission and usher in the end of the world. At this time, everyone will be judged by God based on whether or not they submitted (Islam means ‘submission’ in Arabic) to God in this life. The opening also refers to the “straight path,” which is a common metaphor in Islam for the life of submission to God.

Al-Fatihah (The Opening)

In the name of Allah, the Gracious, the Merciful.

Praise be to Allah, Lord of the Worlds.

The Most Gracious, the Most Merciful.

Master of the Day of Judgment.

It is You we worship, and upon You we call for help.

Guide us to the straight path.

The path of those You have blessed, not of those against whom there is anger, nor of those who are misguided.

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6.2: The Quran

The Quran (Surah 2:1-9)

This passage discusses the importance of the “Book,” which is the Quran itself. One unique aspect of the Quran is that it is very self-reflexive, meaning that the Quran often talks about itself! This passage discusses the idea that the Quran gives “guidance,” touching on the belief in Islam that the Quran is God’s directions to humanity for how to submit to God. It also mentions that people should “believe” what was “revealed before you” which refers to the Muslim belief that there have been earlier revelations before the Quran – namely the Torah and the Gospel. Muslims believe that God also revealed guidance to the Jewish prophets and Jesus, and that guidance was recorded in the Torah and the New Testament. Errors, however, entered into those texts through the recording and transmission process. But it’s important to note that part of being Muslim means that you also believe in the Jewish prophets (like Abraham, David, Moses, etc) and Jesus (though not as divine, just as a prophet).

The passage emphasizes that those who believe in God and follow God’s guidance will be successful – most likely referring to enjoying Paradise, or eternity with God. It also states that those who don’t believe will “have a severe torment,” a reference to hell or an eternal punishment. So we can see that the “Last Day” or “Judgment Day” is a main theme in the Quran.

Access the text here:

www.clearquran.com/001.html

Al-Baqara (The Cow)

In the name of Allah, the Gracious, the Merciful.

Alif, Lam, Meem.

This is the Book in which there is no doubt, a guide for the righteous.

Those who believe in the unseen, and perform the prayers, and give from what We have provided for them.

And those who believe in what was revealed to you, and in what was revealed before you, and are certain of the Hereafter.

These are upon guidance from their Lord. These are the successful.

As for those who disbelieve—it is the same for them, whether you have warned them, or have not warned them—they do not believe.

Allah has set a seal on their hearts and on their hearing, and over their vision is a veil. They will have a severe torment.

Among the people are those who say, “We believe in Allah and in the Last Day,” but they are not believers.

They seek to deceive Allah and those who believe, but they deceive none but themselves, though they are not aware.

And here:

<https://www.clearquran.com/002.html>

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6.3: Surah 96

Surah 96: The Clot (96:1-5)

This short passage consists of the very first words that were revealed to Muhammad in the cave outside of Mecca. When Muhammad was forty years old, he went to Mt. Hira, outside of Mecca, to have a spiritual retreat by himself. During the night, the Angel Gabriel appeared to him and *spoke* these words to him. In the Hadiths, which collect stories about Muhammad, he told others that he heard the words but also felt like the words were being seared into him and that it was a physically and mentally difficult process to receive the revelation. After Muhammad received this revelation, he raced home to his wife Khadija and told her what had happened. She believed his story and suggested he speak to her cousin, Waraqa, who was a Christian. When Waraqa heard the story, he told Muhammad that there had been other revelations in the past, and it sounded like God wanted him to be a prophet to the Arab people.

The angel Gabriel told Muhammad to “read,” which is important for Muslims, because Muhammad was illiterate and told Gabriel that he could not read, but Gabriel pressed on with the second line, commanding him to “read” again. Muhammad’s illiteracy is also important to Muslims because they insist that Muhammad did not have the education to be able to come up with the Quran himself. This passage also states that God “taught by the pen,” which is another reference to the previous revelations that God gave and were recorded in the Jewish and Christian sacred texts.

This passage also showcases another feature of the Quran, which is that it is not ordered chronologically. As you can see, this is from Surah 96, and there are only 114 surahs in the entire Quran. So the very first revelation is placed almost at the end of the Quran. The order of the Quran is believed to have been a revelation in itself that Muhammad received from God near the end of his life after all the revelations had been given. So the ordering is believed to be perfect. Additionally, there are multiple revelations in each Surah – this Surah, Surah 96, contains this revelation

Surah 96: The Clot

Read: In the Name of your Lord who created.

Created man from a clot.

Read: And your Lord is the Most Generous.

He who taught by the pen.

Taught man what he never knew.

Access the text here:

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6.4: Hadith Abu-Dawud

Hadith Abu-Dawud (Book 34, Hadith 85)

This hadith relates a story of something that Muhammad said concerning a certain situation – i.e. the way a woman should dress around men she is not related to. This shows us how hadith functions in Islam. While the Quran is the basis of Islam and gives “guidance” about how to worship and live a life of submission to God, there are many areas that can be quite vague and can be interpreted in multiple ways. One of those areas concerns modesty in dress, especially for women. The Quran says that women should “guard their privates” and “protect their beauty”; these instructions could be interpreted in many ways – what exactly constitutes a woman’s beauty? So that’s where Hadith comes in. Muslims combine teachings that Muhammad gave to help them interpret the Quran. So if a Muslim woman has questions about how to dress, she can look at this Hadith to see that Muhammad said a woman should wear clothing covers everything except her face and hands. There is, of course, still room to interpret that differently, and Muslim women have – some may take this teaching to mean simply long-sleeve shirts and long pants or skirt, while others have worn a very loose outer garment over their clothes to ensure that their figure is not on “display” either.

At the bottom of this Hadith you can see the “isma,” or the chain of transmission. There are thousands and thousands of individual hadith, but not all hadith are created equally! Some hadith are considered more reliable than others, meaning that they are more likely to go all the way back to Muhammad. Every hadith comes with a written chain of transmission – this chain of transmission is supposed to lead from the collector all the way back to Muhammad. This particular hadith is called “mursal,” which means that one of the narrators in the chain of transmission is missing. In this case, the person who heard it Aisha and told it to Khalid b. Duraik is unknown. This means that this hadith is considered authentic by some Muslims but not authentic by others.

This hadith also showcases another important aspect of hadith collection, which is the importance of Aisha. Aisha was the last wife of Muhammad

Asma, daughter of Abu Bakr, entered upon the Messenger of Allah wearing thin clothes. The Messenger of Allah turned his attention from her. He said: O Asma', when a woman reaches the age of menstruation, it does not suit her that she displays her parts of body except this and this, and he pointed to his face and hands.

Abu Dawud said: This is a mursal tradition (i.e. the narrator who transmitted it from 'Aishah is missing) Khalid b. Duraik did not see 'Aishah.

Access the text here:

<https://sunnah.com/abudawud/34>

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Glossary

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